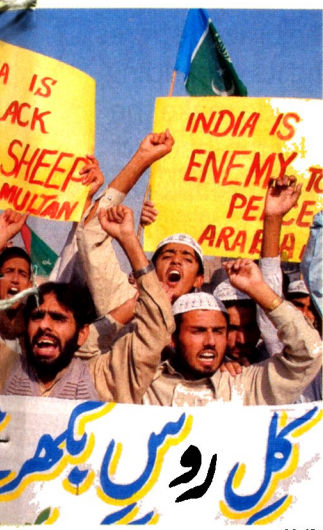




POSSIBLE MILITARY ACTION BY INDIA UNITES ORDINARY PAKISTANIS

Even so, it must tread carefully or risk a violent backlash from elements that support this militancy, especially on Kashmir. It has already seen how the FATA militants, for example, were able to take the fight to the rest of the country. A large segment of Pakistan's society supports the cutting down of these militant networks. But ironically, Indian bellicosity and pressure makes the job much more difficult for the government.

President Zardari recently admitted that "the Mumbai attacks were directed not only at India but also at Pakistan's new democratic government and the peace process with India that we have initiated." With the government struggling with a crippling economic crisis – that has forced recourse to the IMF to avoid a default on debt obligations, high inflationary pressures and a drastic slowdown – on the one hand, and internal political and security turmoil on the other, it could hardly want further erosion of its credibility. As someone who has staked his government's future on economic betterment through better trade relations with India, Zardari understands how the current tension could be a body blow.

Unfortunately, what is needed to deny the Mumbai attackers an even more resounding victory is precisely what has become politically difficult for both India and Pakistan. And that is a more sincere commitment to the peace process.

Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

Union to neutralise the US, building the Mukti Bahini to fight as a liberation force and carefully marshalling its own armed forces to make decisive strikes in Pakistan. "These are defining moments and you don't do them overnight. Patience and planning is the key," he says.

India has to be clear of its end goal which usually translates to what kind of Pakistan does India want. Should Pakistan be to India what Canada is to the US? Does India want a stable Pakistan but not a strong one? Does it want to see the further dismemberment of Pakistan? Does it want to put terrorists operating out of Pakistan out of business? Does it want it to be like Jinnah's Pakistan that L.K. Advani advocated? Or does it want to prove a limited political and psychological point? After determining its objective, what is key for India is not being predictable but looking for smart options.

Getting international pressure put on Pakistan would help. Armed with growing evidence gathered from intelligence agencies investigating the Mumbai attacks, India has mounted a global diplomatic initiative to get Islamabad to hand over some of these fugitives. According to intelligence reports, Dawood was recently admitted at the Army Hospital in Rawalpindi for a kidney illness which has been shared with the US. India then made a strong intervention at the UN Security Council on December 9, on a debate on terrorism asking for the council to ban Jamaat-ud-Daawa, the new front organisation of the L.E.T, which it did.

Officials say the arrested L.E.T leaders should be handed over to India. Pakistan uses both the leaders and the terror group as one of its main lines of defence against India and is therefore wary of handing over assets it has built over the years. If the UPA Government manages to force Pakistan to hand them over, it will be a major step in tackling terrorism. It would also be a deft political move with general elections looming. India also continues to maintain that it "is keeping all options open", including a military strike. But as Tellis points out, "A military strike is the first move but it's not going to be the last one." India must now be acutely aware there is an ambitious general in Pakistan waiting for us to make a false step.

with Saurabh Shukla

now blamed for taking the heat off Al Qaeda-linked militants on the western border. The US also would like to recast the Pakistan Army as a counter-insurgency force against extremist militants and any conflict with India is likely to undermine that plan.

Pakistan's wargamers are also fairly sure that India would find even "surgical strikes" as too risky, given their low utility against rudimentary camps and which could force Pakistan to answer with its own missiles. There is of course the danger of things spiralling out of control between nuclear neighbours.

However, the international pressure to be seen to act against militant networks within Pakistan has forced some moves against Lashkar-e-Toiba camps as well as jihadist operatives identified by India, even though the Government is very unlikely to cede to Indian demands to hand them over.

WANTED CLARITY

India has to be clear of its objectives before it sets out neutralising Pakistan and it must show patience.